United Methodist Homes
Skilled Nursing Home
Policy and Procedure

SUBJECT: WANDERING AND ELOPEMENT RISK IDENTIFICATION AND MANAGEMENT
REGULATION: OBRA: F655, F689, F740, F867, F943 PA: 211.10

POLICY STATEMENT:

It is the policy of United Methodist Homes to maintain facility-wide systems and resident-specific plans of care to minimize resident risk and potential for harm related to wandering and elopement.

DEFINITIONS:

"**Code Green**"- The emergency code used by the UMH to notify staff that a resident is missing and activate the emergency response protocol to conduct search.

"**Elopement**"- The act of a resident leaving the premises or a safe area without authorization (i.e., an order for discharge or leave of absence) and/or any necessary supervision to do so.

"**Elopement Binder**"- A Binder containing resident's name and photo for those residents who are in the Happy Feet Club or are high risk for elopement.

"**Happy Feet Club**" – This is a program that select residents are entered into once they are identified as "at risk for elopement" Their responsible party and in-house physician is contacted, and their care plan is updated. A photo collage is hung at each of our public exits so that families and other residents know to be cautious if they see a resident whose face is present in our Happy Feet Club. These residents will also have a wander-guard pennant on either their person or their wheelchair.

"**Safe wandering**"- Random or repetitive locomotion that is not intrusive or disruptive to other residents and is unlikely to put the wandering resident and/or other residents at heightened risk for injury. A resident with safe wandering behaviors:

a. Has no history of entering areas that are physically hazardous or that contain potential safety hazards (e.g., chemicals, tools, and equipment, etc)

b. Does not display exit seeking behavior; and

c. Does not verbalize desire to leave

"**Supervision/Adequate Supervision**"- An intervention and means of mitigating the risk of an accident. Adequate supervision may vary from resident to resident and from time to time for the same resident.

"**Unsafe wandering**"- Random or repetitive locomotion without regard to physical safety which:

a. Places the wandering resident or other residents at risk of harm;
b. May be disruptive to other residents; and
c. May include attempts by the resident to open doors, enter unsafe areas, or follow others through exit doors.

"**Wander/elopement alarms**"- Devices such as bracelets, pins/buttons worn on the resident's clothing, sensors in shoes, or building/unit exit sensors worn by/attached to the resident that activate an alarm and/or alert the staff when the resident nears or exits a specific area or the building. (This includes devices that are attached to the resident's assistive device (e.g., walker, wheelchair, cane) or other belongings.)

PROCEDURE:

General Staff and Resident/Resident Representative Education and Training

1. Provide staff with general and job-specific education regarding wandering identification, management (including information related to the facility's wandering management system), and elopement prevention and response upon hire, annually, and as needed thereafter.

RESPONSIBILITY: Staff Development

2. Upon admission, ensure residents and resident representatives are provided education regarding the facility's notification protocols when residents leave the facility (e.g., communication process; sign in/out process). There also is a framed instruction guideline hung near the Happy Feet Club Photo Collage for residents, staff, and visitors.

RESPONSIBILITY: Admissions Team

3. Conduct periodic elopement drills to ensure staff implementation of systems and strategies.

RESPONSIBILITY: Plant Operations

Individual Resident Risk Identification and Management-

1. Comprehensively evaluate each resident for wandering behaviors and elopement risk upon admission, at least quarterly, with any significant change in status, and as indicated (i.e., any time the resident presents with new-onset wandering and/or elopement risk).

RESPONSIBILITY: Licensed Staff

2. If wandering behavior is identified:
   a. Conduct the Elopement Evaluation to measure elopement risk.

   b. Determine if the resident's wandering behavior(s) presents a safety risk to the resident and/or others (safe verses unsafe wandering);

RESPONSIBILITY: IDT

3. If risk for elopement is identified:
   a. Develop and maintain a resident-centered interdisciplinary plan of care with interventions aimed to eliminate or decrease such behaviors when possible and to effectively manage unsafe wandering

   b. Modify the plan of care as indicated based upon the resident's condition and response to interventions.

   c. Complete an elopement resident identification form (with photograph and identifying information) and ensure a copy is placed in each facility elopement risk binder; and add resident to "Happy Feet Club"

   d. Reevaluate elopement risk as necessary

RESPONSIBILY: IDT

4. If a resident's plan of care includes the use of a wander/elopement alarm:
   a. Visually verify placement of the alarm over the course of the shift
   b. Document confirmation of device placement every shift at a minimum; and
   c. Immediately report a missing alarm and take necessary actions to ensure resident safety until the alarm is replaced.

RESPONSIBILITY: Nursing Staff

APPROVED BY:

_____ _____

Nursing Home Administrator Date

_____ _____

Director of Nursing Date

REVIEWED/REVISED:9/1/24
